

Module 6: Progressive and Vocational Education

EDUC 219 - Howard University

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1 Module overview

This module examines Progressive Era and vocational approaches to education, including the ways reformers, policymakers, educators, and communities debated the purposes of schooling in a rapidly changing society. We will consider how industrialization, urbanization, immigration, race, class, gender, disability, and changing labor conditions shaped educational reform.

The module asks students to examine both the promises and limits of progressive and vocational education. Educational reform can expand access, support inquiry, connect schools to community life, and create new opportunities. At the same time, reform can reproduce social hierarchies when it sorts students into unequal pathways, defines some forms of knowledge as more valuable than others, or restricts access to rigorous intellectual and civic learning.

2 Guiding questions

- What problems did Progressive Era reformers believe schools should address?
- How did industrialization, urbanization, immigration, and changing labor conditions shape educational reform?
- What did progressive educators mean by child-centered learning, experience, democracy, and social efficiency?
- How did vocational education define preparation for work, citizenship, and adult life?
- Who gained access to expanded educational opportunities, and who was tracked, excluded, or directed into unequal pathways?

- How did race, class, gender, ability, language, and geography shape students' experiences of progressive and vocational education?
- How do debates about curriculum, work, citizenship, and unequal opportunity continue to shape schools today?

3 Key concepts

- Progressive Era
- Progressive education
- Vocational education
- Industrialization and urbanization
- Child-centered learning
- Experiential education
- Social efficiency
- Tracking and differentiation
- Curriculum and citizenship
- Labor, work, and schooling
- Educational reform
- Equal access and unequal pathways

4 Readings and activities

- Givens (2021), Chapter 6 and Conclusion
- Introduction to Ghoddy Muhammad's *Genius and Joy* curriculum
- Additional readings and media on Canvas
- Review of midterm solutions and results
- Trial-preparation groups and in-class run-throughs
- Trial-group discussion: arguments and competing perspectives
- Quiz 3

Trial connection

As trial groups prepare for *Plessy v. Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education*, consider how educational reform, vocational pathways, curriculum, social efficiency, and unequal access shaped the broader educational landscape. Ask how schools can expand opportunity while also reproducing social hierarchies.